MY STORY · LAHORE TO PORTSMOUTH AND BACK

I'm Asad Ikram. This is my story.

- Data engineer
- Chevening Scholar 2024/25
- Co-founder and CTO, Artemis AI

I came to computer science with no computing background and opened my Fiverr account in December 2018. That was the start of **nearly eight years** of data work: SQL tutoring first, then large-scale web and social media data collection, and the pipelines and models that turn that data into decisions people can trust. This page tells the story in order, from school in Lahore to the company I am building now.

Lahore SCHOOL — **Karachi** 2017 — **Chiniot-Faisalabad** 2019 — **Lahore** 2022 — **Portsmouth** 2024 — **Lahore** 2025

442
completed Fiverr ordersFIVERR · FROM NOV 2019

30+
countries my Fiverr buyers came fromFIVERR BUYER MAP

300+
crawlers running daily at Dubizzle LabsLAHORE · 2022 TO 2024

10
countries covered across six productsDUBIZZLE LABS

70,000+
applications in my Chevening cycle, for around 1,500 awards a yearCHEVENING 2024/25

255,446
public comments analysed in my MSc dissertationPORTSMOUTH · 2025

UPDATED 25 OCTOBER 2026

WHERE I'VE WORKED AND STUDIED

National University of computer and emerging sciences · Fiverr · dubizzle group · Fix.com
Chevening · University of Portsmouth · M+C SAATCHI GROUP · M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY
CXG · Prefe · Propre · Artemis AI

BRANDS MY DATA WORK HAS SERVED

Amazon · Ford · UK Government (supported) · Nike
Abbott · durex · Rentokil Initial · CFMOTO

Trademarks belong to their owners. Shown to describe client work through agencies and employers, not endorsement.

THE TIMELINE

From Lahore classrooms to a PhD application

Twelve chapters, in order. Each one has the story, the key facts, and the tools I was using at the time.

01

School years CHAPTER 01 · LAHORE

Growing up in Lahore

I grew up in Lahore. I did my O Levels at Crescent School and my FSc at Crescent College, both in the city. At school I was on the athletics team, running the 200, 400 and 800 metres and relays and competing in the long jump and high jump, and I played for the school football team. At college I took part in speech competitions and played for the college football team. Computers were not part of my schooling; I met them at university.

Looking back, I liked to compete, I liked being part of a team and I was willing to stand up and speak. All three came back later: in leading teams, in my Chevening interview and in pitching a start-up.

Long jump · High jump · 200 m · 400 m · 800 m · Relays · School football · College football · Speech competitions

KEY FACTS

O Levels
Crescent School, Lahore

FSc
Crescent College, Lahore

Urdu and English
Urdu is my first language; English is my working one

O Levels · FSc · Urdu · English

02

2017 CHAPTER 02 · KARACHI

Computer science, from zero

In August 2017 I started a BS in Computer Science at FAST-NUCES, a federally chartered university widely regarded as one of Pakistan's leading institutions for computer science. I began at its Karachi campus, far from home, with no computing background at all.

The first two years were tough. Good teachers and online courses changed that. I found I liked the subject, and then I had a hunger to do more with it than the syllabus asked, because I knew I could. That hunger is what pushed me into freelancing.

KEY FACTS

Aug 2017
BS Computer Science starts at FAST-NUCES

Karachi campus
Aug 2017 to Jan 2019

Computer science · Karachi campus · nu.edu.pk

03

2018 CHAPTER 03 · SUMMERS

Summers with SQL

I spent my university summers teaching myself Python and SQL, and I got properly good at SQL and databases. I took online and paid courses in SQL, data analytics and data warehousing on top of my degree.

On 20 December 2018 I opened a Fiverr seller account, offering SQL help and tutoring for students. Teaching is where the work started: through Fiverr I went on to teach data courses to fellow students and to international students, and client projects grew from there.

KEY FACTS

Dec 2018
Fiverr seller account opened

First role
SQL tutor for students

SQL · Python · Databases · Data warehousing · Teaching

fiverr.com/asadikram56

04

2019 to 2020 CHAPTER 04 · CHINIOT-FAISALABAD

A new campus and the first orders

In January 2019 I transferred to the FAST-NUCES Chiniot-Faisalabad campus, where I finished my degree. It opened in 2012 as the university's fifth campus and its first residential one, and most of my classmates there came from rural areas. In November 2019 my first Fiverr order arrived, and from 2020 work came in regularly.

I did not stay in one lane. I moved from tutoring into data analytics, web data collection, automation scripts, ETL and data pipelines, and I built back-end and front-end web projects with Django and Bootstrap. In June 2020 I delivered a trade-directory data project for a direct client in the UK.

Five-star reviews from clients and professionals abroad were a huge confidence boost. I knew I could make it.

KEY FACTS

Jan 2019
Moved to the Chiniot-Faisalabad campus

Nov 2019
First Fiverr order

200+
websites I collected data from as a freelancer

Five stars
overall rating on Fiverr

Python · Django · Bootstrap · ETL · Data pipelines · Automation · Web data collection

05

2021 CHAPTER 05 · FINAL YEAR

Final year, first remote teams

My final year was busy. From March to May 2021 I did a remote technology internship with **Arthan**, an Indian company: data mining, data analytics, data acquisition and lead generation, and automation that cut manual work. Between June and September I added the Google Data Analytics Certificate,

Python Data Structures from the University of Michigan on Coursera, and HackerRank's Python and Problem Solving certificates. In August I reached Level 2 on Fiverr for the first time.

For my final-year project, a team of three of us designed a **Custom Network Simulator**: a Python simulator of the Wi-Fi (IEEE 802.11) MAC layer with one-click dataset export and graphs, so researchers could generate training data for machine-learning models. Established tools such as NS2, NS3 and OMNeT++ are hard to extend with machine learning, and that was the gap. The idea was my supervisor Dr Bilal Khan's, and it sat far from my data work. I wanted to honour his idea and broaden my skills, which is exactly why I took it on. It taught me how network protocols work and how web traffic is handled.

In November 2021 **Propre**, a Singapore-headquartered property-data company with a Japan office, hired me for a short remote contract as a data engineer. It was my first taste of organised remote work, and of real responsibility: the team worked on Discord, and it showed me how well an organised team can run when everyone is remote. After about three months I left to focus on my final-year project.

KEY FACTS

Mar to May 2021
Remote technology internship, India

Aug 2021
Fiverr Level 2 reached for the first time; later held the Top Seller badge for a while

Grade A
Final-year project

Nov 2021
Short remote contract, Singapore company

Python · IEEE 802.11 · Qt · MySQL · Data analytics · Lead generation

COURSES ACROSS THE DEGREE

Database Systems · Design and Analysis of Algorithms · Linear Algebra · Calculus · Probability and Statistics

propre.com

06

2022 CHAPTER 06 · DUBIZZLE LABS, LAHORE

A blank page at Dubizzle Labs

My degree was conferred on 31 January 2022. I had accepted an offer from Dubizzle Labs while my final exams were still running, and on 1 February I started in Lahore as an Associate Software Engineer. Dubizzle Labs is the technology arm of Dubizzle Group, whose brands at the time included dubizzle and Bayut in the Middle East and Zameen and OLX in Pakistan. The group operates in about ten countries.

The company wanted competitor analysis from public web data, and there was no architecture for it yet. With one colleague in the Dubai team, and guided by two mentors in the Pakistan team, I designed and built the first one on AWS: S3 as the data lake, Glue crawlers, Athena, and a Redshift warehouse in bronze, silver and gold layers, with dashboards in Periscope (Sisense).

This is where I moved from collecting data to using it. I used machine learning for the first time there, estimating competitor growth and revenue from public data, and studying what people discussed, how much volume each site carried, and what worked on each platform and in each region. That summer I took five DataCamp courses in data engineering and Python to go deeper.

KEY FACTS

1 Feb 2022
Associate Software Engineer, Lahore

First
competitor-analysis scraping architecture at the company, built with one Dubai colleague

4 languages
English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi data

`AWS S3` `AWS Glue` `Athena` `Redshift` `Python` `Scrapy` `Selenium` `Periscope (Sisense)` `dubizzlegroup.com`

07

2023 CHAPTER 07 · RUNNING THE FLEET

300 crawlers, every day

In February 2023 I was promoted to Data Engineer. The architecture had become a fleet: more than 300 crawlers running daily, covering six products across ten countries (Pakistan plus nine Middle East and North Africa markets), with the data maintained together with the Dubai team. I ran it, monitored it, extended it and kept crawlers repaired on time. To make it more reliable I added unit tests, CloudWatch alarms and Retool QA apps, built ElasticSearch pipelines, and tuned fact tables for warehouse performance.

I also led the automation scripts that served marketing, finance, SEO and the CEO's team, led hiring for the scraping project, trained colleagues on ETL, and introduced juniors on my team to freelancing.

In May 2023, with Dubizzle's written consent, I started a second, part-time remote role as a data engineer (independent contractor) for **Fix.com** in Canada, an online retailer of appliance and lawn-equipment repair parts and a division of Eldis Group. My job there is data acquisition: finding target sites, building crawlers for retail and parts catalogues, and automating manual work. Flows and pipelines I built in those first months still run. My manager there has been the same person since 2023, and he was later my employer referee for Chevening. Later I added OCR-based machine learning to read parts catalogues from PDFs and models to fill gaps in parts data.

In November 2023 I sent my first Chevening application. At its centre was an idea I still work on: a cross-platform system for analysing public social-media discussion responsibly, so public bodies can read public reaction and make evidence-based decisions at the right time. My example was the business shutdowns in Karachi in September 2023, after fuel and electricity price rises were announced close together. In the same application I named Dr Ella Haig's teaching in Intelligent Data and Text Analytics as a reason to choose Portsmouth, before I had ever met her.

KEY FACTS

Feb 2023
Promoted to Data Engineer

300+
crawlers running daily

6 products
across 10 countries

May 2023
Fix.com, Canada, part time

Nov 2023
First Chevening application

`CloudWatch` `Retool` `ElasticSearch` `Unit tests` `Scrapy` `Python` `fix.com` `chevening.org`

08

2024 CHAPTER 08 · CHEVENING

Senior, selected, and on a plane

In February 2024 I became Senior Data Engineer: two promotions in two years. I led a team of three engineers, two in web scraping and one in data warehousing, and the data-warehouse team for Propforce, Zameen's real-estate affiliate sales platform. I did its data modelling from scratch with Redshift, dbt, Matillion and Airflow, using slowly changing dimensions and star and snowflake schemas.

The Chevening interview invitation came the same month, and I interviewed at the British Council in Lahore in March. I was conditionally selected in June, and my Final Award Letter arrived on 12 August 2024. I left Dubizzle that month, and in mid-September I moved to Portsmouth on my own to start an MSc in Data Analytics at the University of Portsmouth. New country, new city, new people. The Chevening orientation followed in November 2024, and through the University of Portsmouth's Student StartUp team I registered for Venturefest 2024.

CHEVENING SCHOLAR 2024/25

Chevening is the UK Government's international scholarship programme, funded by the FCDO and partner organisations, and it has run since 1983. My award came with a contribution from the University of Portsmouth.

I was selected on my first attempt, in a cycle of **more than 70,000 applications** worldwide (Chevening's figures imply about 72,000). Chevening awards around 1,500 scholarships a year to applicants from over 160 countries and territories; 46 went to Pakistan that year.

From September 2024 I also worked part time and remotely for **Prefe**, a Milan start-up that provides price, promotion and distribution intelligence for consumer-goods brands, as one of its early engineers. I moved its web data collection onto Scrapy and built pipelines into its databases. In December, with the work done and my studies needing more of my time, we parted on good terms.

That same December I won a part-time data engineering role at **M+C Saatchi Fluency**, the data consultancy of M+C Saatchi Group (a London-listed creative network with operations in about 23 countries), through a web-scraping challenge. Fluency has offices in London, New York and Singapore. I work remotely for the London team and daily with colleagues in New York, and I have also worked from the London office at times.

KEY FACTS

Feb 2024
Senior Data Engineer, leading 3 engineers

12 Aug 2024
Chevening Final Award Letter

Sep 2024
MSc starts in Portsmouth; Prefe, Milan

Dec 2024
M+C Saatchi Fluency, London

`Redshift` `dbt` `Matillion` `Airflow` `BigQuery` `Snowflake` `Star schema` `Scrapy`

`chevening.org` `port.ac.uk` `prefe.it` `mcsaatchi.com` `fluency-mcsaatchi.com`

09

2025 CHAPTER 09 · PORTSMOUTH

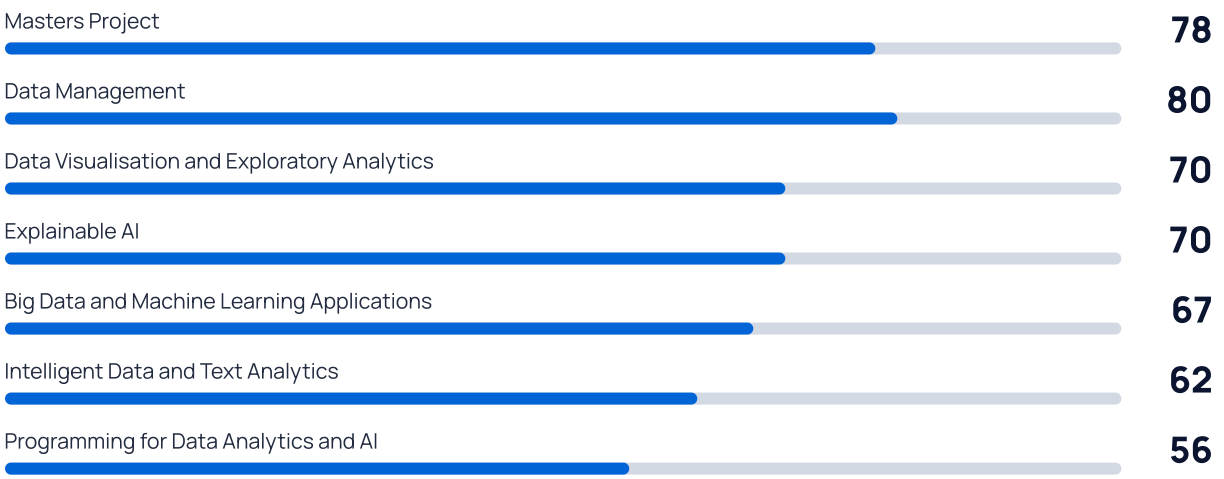
A dissertation, a start-up, a Distinction

The MSc is where I got much more interested in machine learning and AI. I worked hands-on with Apache Spark on the university's computing cluster and used it in my projects. I made friends from Italy, France, Spain, Greece, Nigeria, the USA and India, and I mentored classmates who arrived without a data background. My professors shaped where I am going: Dr Ella Haig, Dr Fahad Ahmad and Dr Rahim Taheri, the MSc programme coordinator.

In February 2025 I co-founded **Artemis AI** in the UK as CTO, with a partner I met while living there. In April I registered for Chevening Ideas Connect: AI and Cybersecurity, in Lancaster. In June and July I was also Lead Data Engineer, part time, at **VendueTech**, a European proptech start-up, reporting to its CTO and leading three developers on real-time auction data pipelines and its Azure-to-AWS migration work with an AWS partner. I left when that migration project stopped, to focus on my MSc and my other work.

My dissertation, supervised by Dr Ella Haig, was a cross-platform sentiment analysis of public reaction to UK economic policies: **255,446 public comments** from X/Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, collected through official APIs and licensed data access, under university ethics approval and with user IDs hashed. I compared a VADER lexicon baseline, a BiLSTM and a fine-tuned BERT model, calibrated them, tested differences with McNemar and bootstrap tests, forecast trends with Prophet, measured emotion with the NRC lexicon, and explained predictions with LIME and integrated gradients. It earned a mark of 78.

MSC MODULES AND MARKS · CREDIT-WEIGHTED AVERAGE 70.5



In September 2025 my study ended. I was welcomed into the Chevening alumni network, said goodbye at the Chevening Farewell at Alexandra Palace in London, and took ownership of Amazon's social-media analytics pipeline at Fluency. From late 2025 I also started working as a data engineer for **CXG**, a Dubai-based customer-experience consultancy, on data from global fashion and luxury brands. My MSc was awarded with **Distinction** on 8 December 2025, and that month I came home to Lahore, as Chevening scholars agree to do. Chevening has since confirmed that this is no problem for a PhD starting in 2027. During my year in the UK I went to events and made connections that still matter to me.

KEY FACTS

Distinction MSc Data Analytics, average 70.5	**78** Dissertation mark	**255,446** comments across 4 platforms
Feb 2025 Co-founded Artemis AI as CTO	**Dec 2025** Back to Lahore	

`Apache Spark` `PySpark` `BERT` `BiLSTM` `VADER` `Prophet` `LIME` `AWS Batch` `Step Functions` `Playwright`

`artemisai.co.uk` `port.ac.uk` `cxg.com`

10

Jan to Jul 2026 CHAPTER 10 · LAHORE

Back in Lahore, still building

Artemis AI Ltd was incorporated in the UK in January 2026. From Lahore I carried on with Fluency, Fix.com and Artemis, and went back to CXG for further engagements. One CXG problem I enjoy: the same product attribute is written differently by region and language, so "K18WG", "18K white gold" and "750/1000 white gold" have to become one shared vocabulary before anyone can compare brands.



By February I was also co-leading **ScrapeSync**, a small web-scraping team. In May I started **web-scraping-guide.com**, a free, no-signup engineering guide to web data collection, including its legal and ethical limits. It is how I wanted to give back after my Chevening year.

In June I became the sole designer and operator of Fix.com's crawler platform. **ScrapeYard** is a FastAPI control plane with a crawler registry, scheduling, live logs, on-demand data-quality checks, named logins with per-action audit trails, and Google Drive delivery. When a crawler breaks, AI can propose a fix, but it comes back as a diff that a person reviews; nothing commits on its own. It runs on an inexpensive VPS rather than managed cloud services.

In mid-2026 I also began advising a US travel-technology company (under NDA) on its large-scale data-collection architecture. I have also helped Metoda, a company in Germany. And in July, with the Fluency team, I built a one-off collection across 20 powersports forums, plus Reddit through its official API.

KEY FACTS

Jan 2026 Artemis AI Ltd incorporated	**May 2026** Free guide launched	**10.03M** rows delivered by ScrapeYard across 82 datasets (Oct 2026)
~331 ScrapeYard commits, all mine, Jun to 4 Oct 2026		

`FastAPI` `Scrapy` `Scrapyd` `APScheduler` `GitHub Actions` `Linux and systemd` `Google Drive API` `Reddit API`

`scrapesync.io` `web-scraping-guide.com` `fix.com`

11

Aug to Oct 2026 CHAPTER 11 · AGENTS AND A PAPER

AI agents, a preprint and PhD applications

In August 2026 a developer advocate at Zyte got in touch because of the guide. Zyte's developer-relations team then interviewed me, invited me to review a pre-release version of its open-source agentic scraping toolkit, and later gave me two complimentary passes to the Web Data Extract Summit in Dublin.

At Fluency, **Crawler IQ**, the system I built and own for Ford, is a fleet of more than 60 car-owner forum crawlers with two AI agents: a healer that diagnoses a broken crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages, and a builder that creates new crawlers from a brief. Their changes ship only after verification. By 9 October 2026, across 1,697 runs, the healer had fixed 86% of broken crawlers and the builder had succeeded on 92% of builds.

I also own Amazon's CORE social-media analytics pipeline, whose master table holds about 2.2 million rows. In October I refactored it onto Fluency's shared data platform and checked parity file by file: all 138 exported files came out byte-identical. Alongside that, I built a 12-month US consumer discourse study for M+C Saatchi's New York team, with more than 100,000 consumer mentions, an 18-theme codebook that the team signed off, and a prompt version recorded on every machine label. I also support a UK government social-media analytics pipeline, and work on projects for global brands in consumer health, automotive, e-commerce and sport. Alongside the pipelines I build dashboards and internal websites for the team.

14 OCTOBER 2026 · FIRST PREPRINT

My first preprint went live on arXiv (not peer reviewed), written with Dr Ella Haig and endorsed for arXiv by Dr Rahim Taheri: a protocol for checking whether platforms change what machine-labelled sentiment means. More in Research and PhD.

The same month I applied to PhD programmes starting in 2027 in Europe, the UK and Singapore, with programmes in the US next on my list.

KEY FACTS

1,697 runs
86% healed, 92% of builds succeeded

~2.2M
rows in the Amazon CORE master table

138 of 138
files byte-identical after the refactor

arXiv:2610.16757
preprint, 14 Oct 2026

`Claude over MCP` `Scrapy` `FastAPI` `AWS Lambda` `ECS Fargate` `PostgreSQL` `Tableau` `BERTopic` `arXiv:2610.16757` `GitHub code` `Zenodo DOI` `mcsaatchi.com/americas`

12

Next CHAPTER 12 · LATE 2026 AND 2027

What comes next

In November 2026 I plan to be at the Web Data Extract Summit in Dublin, which Zyte calls the world's largest web-scraping conference. Artemis AI opens a free invited beta on iOS and Android on 15 December 2026, with a public launch planned for 2027.

I am planning further work with Dr Haig. And if I am admitted, I start a PhD in 2027.

KEY FACTS

10 to 11 Nov 2026
Web Data Extract Summit, Dublin

15 Dec 2026
Artemis AI invited beta

2027
PhD start, if admitted

`Measurement` `Cross-platform NLP` `Multilingual text` `Product launch`

`artemisai.co.uk`

ROLES AT A GLANCE

Every role, on one line each

Study, freelance work, employers, contracts and the things I run myself, from August 2017 to October 2026. Several ran side by side, which is why the bars overlap.

STUDY AND SCHOLARSHIP

BS Computer Science
FAST-NUCES, Karachi then Chiniot-Faisalabad
Aug 2017 to Jan 2022

MSc Data Analytics, Distinction
University of Portsmouth
Sep 2024 to Sep 2025

Chevening Scholar 2024/25
Chevening, UK Government
Sep 2024 to Sep 2025

WORK

Freelance data engineer
Fiverr and direct clients
Dec 2018 to Feb 2026

Technology Intern, remote
Arthan, an Indian company
Mar to May 2021

Data Engineer, short remote contract
Propre Pte. Ltd., Singapore, with a Japan office
Nov 2021 to Jan 2022

Associate Software Engineer, Data Engineer, Senior Data Engineer
Dubizzle Labs, Lahore
Feb 2022 to Aug 2024

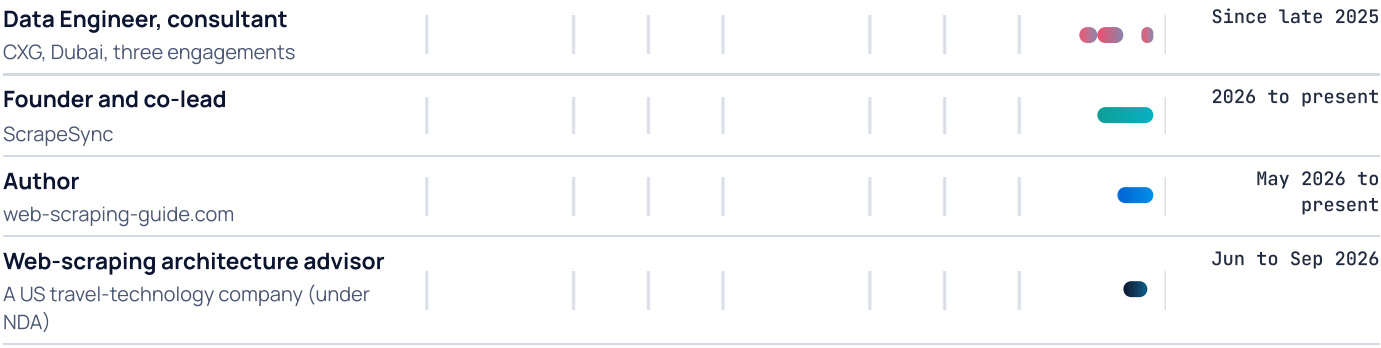
Data Engineer, independent contractor
Fix.com (Eldis Group, Canada)
May 2023 to present

Data Engineer, part time
Prefe, Milan
Sep to Dec 2024

Data Engineer, part time
M+C Saatchi Fluency, London
Dec 2024 to present

Co-Founder and CTO
Artemis AI, UK
Feb 2025 to present

Lead Data Engineer, part time
VendueTech, a European proptech start-up
Jun to Jul 2025



Bars marked with a dot at the end are ongoing in October 2026. At Dubizzle Labs the three segments are my three titles.

FREELANCE, SINCE 2018

Clients in more than 30 countries

Fiverr is where I learned to work with clients anywhere. **442 completed orders**, more than 300 five-star reviews Level 2 Seller status (first reached August 2021) and, for a while, the Top Seller badge, with buyers spread across these countries.

442	300+	33	200+
completed orders	five-star reviews	countries listed here	websites collected from

From a student room in Pakistan to buyers on six continents

Every arc starts in Lahore. Fiverr's own analytics put my buyer map at 22 percent of the world: North America, Western Europe and the Nordics, the Gulf and North Africa, South and Southeast Asia, Australia, South Africa and Peru.

Most of those orders were data work: SQL, analytics, and collecting and cleaning web data for people who needed it to make a decision.

Americas — 3 COUNTRIES

- United States
- Canada
- Peru

Western Europe — 7 COUNTRIES

- United Kingdom
- Ireland
- France
- Belgium
- Netherlands
- Germany
- Switzerland

Nordics — 4 COUNTRIES

- Denmark
- Norway
- Sweden
- Finland

Southern and Eastern Europe — 8 COUNTRIES

- Spain
- Portugal
- Italy
- Greece
- Poland
- Romania
- Ukraine
- Russia

Middle East and North Africa — 4 COUNTRIES

- Türkiye
- Saudi Arabia
- Egypt
- Algeria

South Asia — 2 COUNTRIES

- Pakistan
- India

Southeast Asia and Oceania — 4 COUNTRIES

- Thailand
- Malaysia
- Philippines
- Australia

Sub-Saharan Africa — 1 COUNTRY

- South Africa

Read from Fiverr's buyer-geography map, so treat the list as approximate; a few countries that are hard to read on the map are left off. Fiverr's map labelled my reach **"22% world domination"**. Outside Fiverr I also worked directly for clients in the UK (2020) and California (2022 and 2026).

COUNTRIES AND TEAMS

The teams I have worked with

Beyond the Fiverr buyers above, these are the organisations and teams I have worked in or with, by country. Most of it was remote, from Lahore and Portsmouth.

Pakistan

Dubizzle Labs in Lahore, on site, 2022 to 2024. Home base again since December 2025.

United Kingdom

M+C Saatchi Fluency in London, Artemis AI, the University of Portsmouth and Chevening.

United States

Daily work with M+C Saatchi colleagues in New York, a US travel-technology company (under NDA) and a direct client in California.

Canada

Fix.com, part of Eldis Group, since May 2023.

United Arab Emirates

The Dubai team at Dubizzle, and CXG in Dubai since late 2025.

Italy

Prefe in Milan, as one of its early engineers, in 2024.

Singapore and Japan

Propre, a Singapore-headquartered property-data company with a Japan office, in 2021 and 2022.

India

Arthan, a remote technology internship in 2021.

🇩🇪 **Germany and Europe**

Metoda in Germany, and VendueTech, a European proptech start-up, in 2025.

THE THREAD

Every system I built left me with the same question: do these numbers really mean what we think they mean? Industry gave me the question. Research is where I want to answer it, and then bring the answer back to the people who rely on it.

LAHORE · PORTSMOUTH · LAHORE

COMMUNITY AND MENTORING

Helping other people get started

Freelancing showed me what I could do. The most useful thing I can do with that is help other people get there faster.

UNIVERSITY · PUNJAB

First in their families

At university I helped several fellow students from remote parts of Punjab start freelancing. They were the first in their families to reach a university like ours, and money was tight. I set up their freelance accounts, passed clients to them, taught them the skills, and kept mentoring them outside work.

FIVERR · TEACHING

Data courses for students

Through Fiverr I taught data courses to fellow students and to international students, starting with the SQL that got me going.

DUBIZZLE LABS

Juniors on my team

I mentored the juniors on my team, trained colleagues on ETL, and introduced juniors to freelancing.

PORTSMOUTH

Classmates new to data

On my MSc I mentored classmates who arrived without a data background.

SCRAPESYNC

A small team I co-lead

ScrapeSync is a small web-scraping services team and brand that I co-lead. It lets me take on bigger freelance work and lead a team doing it.

scrapesync.io

DISCORD · REDDIT · STACK OVERFLOW · GITHUB

Online communities

I help people get unstuck in web-scraping communities on Discord and Reddit, answer questions on Stack Overflow and share open source on GitHub.

WEB-SCRAPING-GUIDE.COM · SINCE MAY 2026

A free field guide to web data collection

Asad's Guide to Web Scraping 2026 is a free, no-signup engineering guide to resilient, large-scale web data collection that respects platform terms, using official APIs where available and polite rate limits. It covers the legal and ethical limits too, and I update it weekly.

23	255	91	11
sections	cards	libraries compared	pipeline designs

Figures as of 30 September 2026. Readers have written in, a recruiter among them, and it is how Zyte's developer-relations team found me and interviewed me.

web-scraping-guide.com

ZYTE · DUBLIN

Invited to review

In August 2026 Zyte's developer-relations team interviewed me and invited me to review a pre-release version of its open-source agentic scraping toolkit. They also gave me two complimentary passes to the Web Data Extract Summit 2026 in Dublin.

A PROMISE FROM 2023

What I told Chevening I would do

In my 2023 Chevening application I wrote that I wanted to run webinars and data-collection courses at universities, help under-privileged students into freelancing, and build a bridge between Chevening scholars and local talent in Pakistan. Some of that is still a plan. The free guide and the mentoring are the parts I have started.

PEOPLE WHO SHAPED ME

I did not get here alone

Professors are named; managers and colleagues are described by their role.

EH

Dr Ella Haig

ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR IN AI, UNIVERSITY OF PORTSMOUTH

Supervised my dissertation and co-wrote my first preprint. I named her teaching in my 2023 Chevening application, before I had met her.

BK

Dr Bilal Khan

MY FINAL-YEAR PROJECT SUPERVISOR, FAST-NUCES

The network simulator was his idea, and I took it on to honour it and to broaden my skills.

FA

Dr Fahad Ahmad

SENIOR LECTURER, UNIVERSITY OF PORTSMOUTH

Taught and assessed me on the MSc, and is a referee for my PhD applications.

RT

Dr Rahim Taheri

MSC PROGRAMME COORDINATOR, UNIVERSITY OF PORTSMOUTH

Endorsed my preprint for arXiv.

FN

My teachers at FAST-NUCES

KARACHI AND CHINIOT-FAISALABAD

They turned two hard first years into a subject I wanted to do more of.

DL

Two mentors at Dubizzle Labs

THE PAKISTAN TEAM

They guided me while I designed the first scraping architecture as a new associate.

FX

My manager at Fix.com

SINCE 2023

The same manager from my first month, and later my employer referee for Chevening.

7

Classmates from seven countries

PORTSMOUTH, 2024 TO 2025

Friends from Italy, France, Spain, Greece, Nigeria, the USA and India.

RESEARCH AND PHD

One question since 2023

Brands, start-ups and public bodies act on numbers taken from social media. I want to know when those numbers can be trusted, across platforms and across languages.

2023

Chevening essay

A cross-platform system to read public reaction responsibly and inform decisions.

2025

MSc dissertation

255,446 comments on UK economic policy, four platforms. Distinction.

2026

Preprint

Is the platform part of the measurement? With Dr Ella Haig.

2027

PhD, if admitted

Does machine-labelled opinion mean the same across platforms, languages and scripts?

MSC DISSERTATION · 2025

What my dissertation taught me

"Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies", supervised by Dr Ella Haig. To check my labels I hand-labelled 200 posts myself; agreement with VADER was a kappa of about 0.78. The bigger lessons were about what I had got wrong:

01 The classifier's apparent accuracy measured agreement with the lexicon that made its labels, not accuracy.

02 I treated the platforms as if they measured opinion the same way. They do not have to.

03 The English-only pipeline dropped posts written in Urdu and Hindi.

Together, those three lessons became the preprint and my PhD direction.

PREPRINT · NOT PEER REVIEWED

Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?

> Ikram, A. and Haig, E. (2026). "Is the Platform Part of the Measurement? A Protocol and Simulation Study for Cross-Platform Equivalence of Machine-Labelled Policy Sentiment." arXiv:2610.16757. Version 1.1, 25 pages; cs.LG, cross-listed in cs.CL, cs.CY and cs.SI.

It treats each platform like a survey mode and sets out a six-step protocol:

01 Fixed anchor events

02 A generalizability study against human labels

03 Measurement invariance and DIF

04 A multilevel model

05 Score linking

06 A 500-replication known-truth simulation

The simulation shows that pooling sentiment across platforms misleads when platforms measure differently and the mix of platforms shifts, and that relative linking fixes it. The strongest headline comparison holds only when the true measurement functions are assumed known; with a realistic reference point the advantage shrinks. It has not yet been applied to real data. An experienced reviewer judged the idea sound but found the hand-labelled set and corpus from my MSc, which motivate it, small. That tells me what to fix next.

Next: I am planning further work with Dr Haig.

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arxiv.org/abs/2610.16757 github.com/asadfix/platform-measurement

DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23105129

PHD DIRECTION · APPLYING FOR 2027

Where I want to take it

My PhD proposals ask whether opinion labelled by language models and classifiers means the same thing across platforms, languages and scripts. The plan uses designs that hold the content fixed, and a Roman Urdu political-stance gold set.

The motive is practical. I want to solve the problems I meet at Artemis AI academically first, and then in the product. I am applying to programmes in social-media research and web data collection, starting in 2027, including CSH Vienna, the University of Edinburgh and NUS. Several of the professors I wrote to replied positively, and one gave critical feedback that sharpened the proposal.

LANGUAGES AND SCRIPTS IN SCOPE

URDU SCRIPT	LATIN SCRIPT	LANGUAGE	CODE-MIXED
اردو Urdu	Roman Urdu	English	Hinglish

EVERYTHING I'VE BUILT

Systems, studies and side projects

One card per thing I designed, built, own or led, with the stack I used and a link where one is public. Client work is described, never its findings.

300+	60+	10.03M	48	3.39M	255,446
crawlers running daily at Dubizzle Labs	forum crawlers in Crawler IQ	rows delivered by ScrapeYard (Oct 2026)	models in the Artemis AI architecture	public comments collected for Artemis AI	comments in my MSc dissertation

M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY · FOR FORD · I BUILT AND OWN IT

Crawler IQ

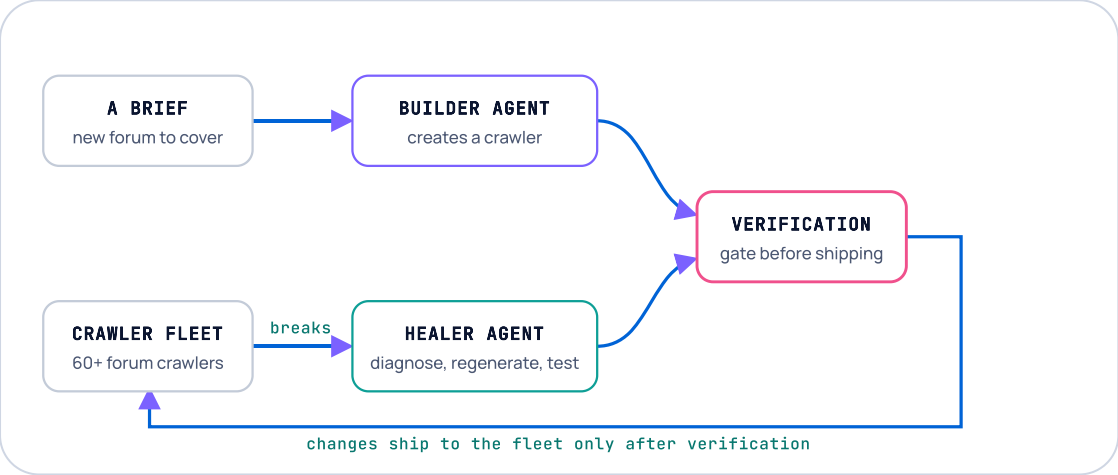
A fleet of more than 60 car-owner forum crawlers with two AI agents. A healer diagnoses a broken crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages. A builder creates new crawlers from a brief. Their changes ship only after verification.

86%
of broken crawlers fixed by the healer

92%
of builds succeeded

1,697
runs, to 9 Oct 2026

`Scrapy` `FastAPI` `Claude over MCP` `AWS EC2` `RDS PostgreSQL` `Athena` `GitHub Actions`



FIX.COM · SINCE JUN 2026

ScrapeYard

Fix.com's crawler platform for repair-parts catalogues: a FastAPI control plane with a crawler registry, scheduling, live logs, data-quality checks, named logins with audit trails and Google Drive delivery. AI-suggested repairs come back as a diff that a person reviews.

`10.03M rows across 82 datasets (Oct 2026)`

`FastAPI` `Scrapy` `Scrapyd` `APScheduler` `GitHub Actions`

`fix.com`

ARTEMIS AI · SINCE FEB 2025

Artemis AI and Art-E

Social-media intelligence for Facebook and Instagram pages, read-only through Meta's official Graph APIs, with Art-E as its AI advisor. I lead the architecture, evaluation, data governance and planning as co-founder and CTO.

`48 models in the architecture, about 10 running weekly`

`Apache Iceberg` `Athena` `DeBERTa-v3` `pgvector` `AWS London`

`artemisai.co.uk`

M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY · OWNER SINCE SEP 2025

Amazon CORE pipeline

Amazon's social-media analytics pipeline: exports are cleaned, deduplicated and translated, then loaded into PostgreSQL for Tableau. In October 2026 I refactored it onto Fluency's shared data platform and checked parity file by file.

`138 of 138 files byte-identical after the refactor`

AWS Lambda · ECS Fargate · PostgreSQL · Tableau

fluency-mcsaatchi.com

M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY · FOR THE NEW YORK TEAM

US consumer discourse study

A 12-month study of more than 100,000 consumer mentions, with an 18-theme codebook that the team signed off and a prompt version recorded on every machine label.

`100,000+ consumer mentions`

BERTopic · LLM tagging · Versioned prompts

mcsaatchi.com/americas

M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY · JUL 2026, WITH THE TEAM

Powersports forum collection

A one-off collection across 20 powersports forums, plus Reddit through its official API, with offline parsing tests and a small dashboard.

`20 forums plus Reddit`

Scrapy · Reddit API · Offline tests

SINCE MAY 2026

web-scraping-guide.com

A free, no-signup engineering guide to web data collection that respects platform terms, using official APIs where available and polite rate limits. It covers the legal and ethical limits too, and I update it weekly.

`23 sections, 255 cards, 91 libraries compared (Sep 2026)`

Static site · Knowledge graph · llms.txt

web-scraping-guide.com · GitHub source

SINCE 2026

ScrapeSync

A small web-scraping services team I co-lead, so I can take on bigger freelance work and lead a team doing it.

`Co-lead with a small team of engineers`

Web data collection · Team lead

scrapesync.io

WITH DR ELLA HAIG · OCT 2026

Platform-measurement code

The code behind the preprint: a six-step protocol for cross-platform equivalence of machine-labelled sentiment and a 500-replication known-truth simulation.

`Preprint, not peer reviewed`

Python · Simulation · Score linking

arXiv · GitHub · Zenodo DOI

UNIVERSITY OF PORTSMOUTH · 2025

MSc dissertation pipeline

Cross-platform sentiment analysis of public reaction to UK economic policies, from data collected through official APIs and licensed data access, with VADER, BiLSTM and fine-tuned BERT, calibration, significance tests, Prophet forecasting and explanations.

255,446 comments from 4 platforms; mark 78

BERT · BiLSTM · VADER · Prophet · LIME

port.ac.uk

DUBIZZLE LABS, LAHORE · 2022 TO 2024

Competitor-analysis architecture

The company's first web-scraping architecture for competitor analysis, designed and built on AWS with one colleague in the Dubai team, with a bronze, silver and gold Redshift warehouse and Periscope dashboards.

300+ crawlers daily; 6 products in 10 countries

S3 · Glue · Athena · Redshift · Scrapy

dubizzlegroup.com

DUBIZZLE LABS · 2024

Propforce data warehouse

Data modelling from scratch for Zameen's real-estate affiliate sales platform, leading its data-warehouse team, with slowly changing dimensions and star and snowflake schemas.

Led the warehouse team

Redshift · dbt · Matillion · Airflow

CXG, DUBAI · SINCE LATE 2025

Luxury product-data normalisation

Crawlers, tests and analysis for global fashion and luxury brands, turning one attribute written differently by region and language into a shared vocabulary so brands can be compared.

Three engagements

Python · pytest · Normalisation

cxg.com

PREFE, MILAN · 2024

Scrapy migration

As one of the early engineers at a retail price-intelligence start-up, I moved its web data collection onto Scrapy and built pipelines into its databases.

Part time, remote

Scrapy · Pipelines · Databases

prefe.it

VENDUETECH · 2025

Auction data pipelines

As Lead Data Engineer I led three developers on real-time auction data pipelines and Azure-to-AWS migration work for a European proptech start-up.

Led three developers

Scrapy · Playwright · AWS Batch · Step Functions · PySpark

FAST-NUCES · 2021

Custom Network Simulator

My final-year project, designed in a team of three: a Python simulator of the Wi-Fi (IEEE 802.11) MAC layer with one-click dataset export and graphs, so researchers could generate training data for machine-learning models.

Grade A

Python · Qt · MySQL · IEEE 802.11

nu.edu.pk

FIVERR · 2019 TO 2026

Freelance data projects

SQL tutoring, analytics, automation scripts, ETL, web data collection and Django and Bootstrap web projects for buyers in more than 30 countries.

442 completed orders; 200+ websites

SQL · Python · Django · ETL

fiverr.com/asadikram56

WHAT I AM BUILDING

Artemis AI

Large companies can afford social-media intelligence. Most creators and small businesses cannot. Artemis AI is a UK start-up that aims to give them the same kind of insight, so they can compete. I am its co-founder and CTO.

SINCE FEBRUARY 2025 · UK

Social-media intelligence for Facebook and Instagram pages

Artemis connects to a page through Meta's official Graph APIs with read-only access, reads its posts, comments and insights, and turns them into advice the owner can act on. It never posts or replies.

● Pre-launch · free invited beta on iOS and Android from 15 Dec 2026 · public launch planned for 2027

artemisai.co.uk

E Meet Art-E

Art-E, our AI advisor, tells a page owner what their audience is saying and what to do next.

What to reply to · When to post · Whether a draft will land · Early warning of comment storms · Possible collaboration partners

48 models in the architecture, across 7 families

~10 running in weekly production

3.39M public comments collected from Facebook pages

4 contractors I lead: AI/ML, back end, product design, legal

HOW IT IS BUILT, LAYER BY LAYER

01 **Sources**

Facebook and Instagram Graph APIs, read-only.

02 **Collection**

Posts, comments and insights; hourly growth curves for posts up to 14 days old; a 90-day backfill when a page connects.

03 **Warehouse**

Apache Iceberg tables with an Athena star schema. Facebook and Instagram sit side by side and are never added together.

04 **Models**

Our own NLP models first, a large language model only below a confidence floor. Five DeBERTa-v3 comment models read each comment with its post; images go through OCR and CLIP; video through frames, speech-to-text and OCR.

05 **Serving**

PostgreSQL with pgvector, and a model registry.

06 **Art-E**

Retrieval over the page's own data with a safety guard. Every number must come from a checked tool, and unsourced numbers are blocked. An LLM judge runs on 200 test questions, and the next-move picker holds back 10% to prove it helps.

07 **App**

iPhone and Android, hosted in AWS London.

RESPONSIBLE BY DESIGN

- ○ Read-only Meta permissions
- ○ Commenter IDs are never stored, and tagged names become "user"
- ○ Audience overlap kept only as page-pair counts of 5 or more
- ○ A UK-only data rule
- ○ A legal check that no AI vendor trains on customer content
- ○ Comment storms judged against each page's own normal

MY PART, AND THE TEAM'S

As CTO I lead the architecture, evaluation and QA dashboards, data governance and permissions, crisis definitions, and the planning and tracker. I set up the mobile app repository with CI and a protected main branch, and I take part in pitching and fundraising presentations.

I brought four contractors into the team, and our AI/ML and back-end engineers wrote most of the model pipelines. The whole company team is about eight people, including the co-founders.

WHAT IT TAUGHT ME

Agreement between models is not accuracy, so our tracker calls it an accuracy proxy. Banter, dialect and non-English text are where models fail first, and our OCR reads only English. Those lessons are a big part of why I want a PhD.

THE THREAD THROUGH ALL OF IT

Numbers from social media can be quietly wrong

LANGUAGE	Posts in other languages get dropped.
TONE	Banter gets read as anger.
ACCURACY	Agreement between models gets passed off as accuracy.
PLATFORMS	Pooled platforms shift results when the platform mix changes.

MY ANSWER HAS TWO HALVES

Measure it, then build the checks in

Measurement

The protocol in my preprint, and the PhD that should follow it.

Engineering

Verification gates on AI-repaired crawlers, versioned prompts, codebooks that people sign off, clearly flagged estimates, read-only data access and no stored commenter identities.

My personal goal, unchanged since my Chevening application, is to help public bodies read public reaction responsibly and decide at the right time. Today I pursue it through work like the UK government pipeline I support at Fluency.

"My journey has not stopped; it has started."

ASAD IKRAM, OCTOBER 2026

LESSONS

What the work taught me

Teaching is where the work started.

FIVERR, 2018

An organised team can run well when everyone is remote.

PROPRE, 2021

Websites change without warning, so most of running a crawler fleet is repairing it on time.

DUBIZZLE LABS, 2022 TO 2024

Agreement between models is not accuracy.

MSC AND ARTEMIS AI

Banter, dialect and non-English text are where models fail first.

ARTEMIS AI

Platforms do not have to measure opinion the same way.

THE PREPRINT, 2026

An AI fix is a suggestion until a person or a verification gate says otherwise.

SCRAPEYARD AND CRAWLER IQ

Count coverage from what was fetched, not from what was scheduled.

SCRAPEYARD, 2026

A WEEK IN MY WORK NOW

Several teams, one week

From Lahore, in October 2026. These run side by side, part time, across time zones from New York to Dubai.

M+C SAATCHI FLUENCY · LONDON AND NEW YORK

Pipelines for global brands

The weekly Crawler IQ run for Ford, the Amazon CORE pipeline I own, support for a UK government social-media analytics pipeline, and dashboards for the team.

FIX.COM · CANADA

ScrapeYard

Crawlers for repair-parts catalogues, the data-quality gate, and deliveries to Google Drive.

ARTEMIS AI · UK

Getting to the beta

The sprint plan to launch, architecture and evaluation, and about 10 models running in weekly production.

CXG · DUBAI

Luxury product data

Crawlers, tests and analysis for global fashion and luxury brands, in the engagement that began in September 2026.

COMMUNITY

The guide and ScrapeSync

The weekly update to web-scraping-guide.com, ScrapeSync work with the team I co-lead, and advisory work for a US travel-technology company (under NDA).

RESEARCH

PhD applications

Proposals, emails to professors and further work with Dr Haig.

WHAT'S NEXT

The next six months, and after

What I want now is to make social media easier to understand for the people who have the least help doing it.

10 to 11 Nov 2026

Web Data Extract Summit, Dublin

On the two complimentary passes from Zyte's developer-relations team.

1 Dec 2026

Artemis AI first pilots

Ahead of the invited beta.

15 Dec 2026

Artemis AI invited beta

Free, on iOS and Android, with a public launch planned for 2027. My own aim, not yet a company plan, is to grow Artemis into the USA one day.

2027

A PhD, if admitted

To solve the problems I meet at Artemis AI academically first, then in the product, while planning further work with Dr Haig.

Thanks for reading

If any of this overlaps with what you are working on, I would like to hear from you.

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PORTFOLIO

asad-ikram-mc.github.io/portfolio

LinkedIn · Fiverr · web-scraping-guide.com · scrapesync.io · artemisai.co.uk · GitHub · arXiv preprint